Understanding Global Life Expectancy

This report analyzes life expectancy at birth (the average number of years a newborn is expected to live) from the World Health Organization (WHO) and the United Nations, covering various countries and regions from 2000 to 2021.

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Defining Our Goals

Objective

Behind every life expectancy number is a story of inequality. This analysis explores which countries lead and lag, whether men and women experience these gaps differently, and whether the world is making progress.

Questions Explored

To make sense of the data, this analysis focused on three main questions

- Which 10 countries have the highest average life expectancy, and which 10 have the lowest?
- Is there a significant difference between the life expectancy of men and women in the countries above?
- How has life expectancy changed over the last 10 years (from 2012 to 2021) for the top and bottom performing countries?

Preparing the Data for Analysis

What was noticed at first glance

- The raw data was cluttered with technical codes and redundant columns that made it hard to read.

- Some columns contained the same information for every single row, so these were removed to simplify the view.

Key cleaning steps included:

- Renaming columns like I also renamed the “GEO_NAME_SHORT” to “COUNTRY_REGION”, and “DIM_TIME” to “YEAR” for better clarity.

- Rounding life expectancy numbers to two decimal places to make them easier to compare.

- Removing technical ID columns that did not add value to the story.

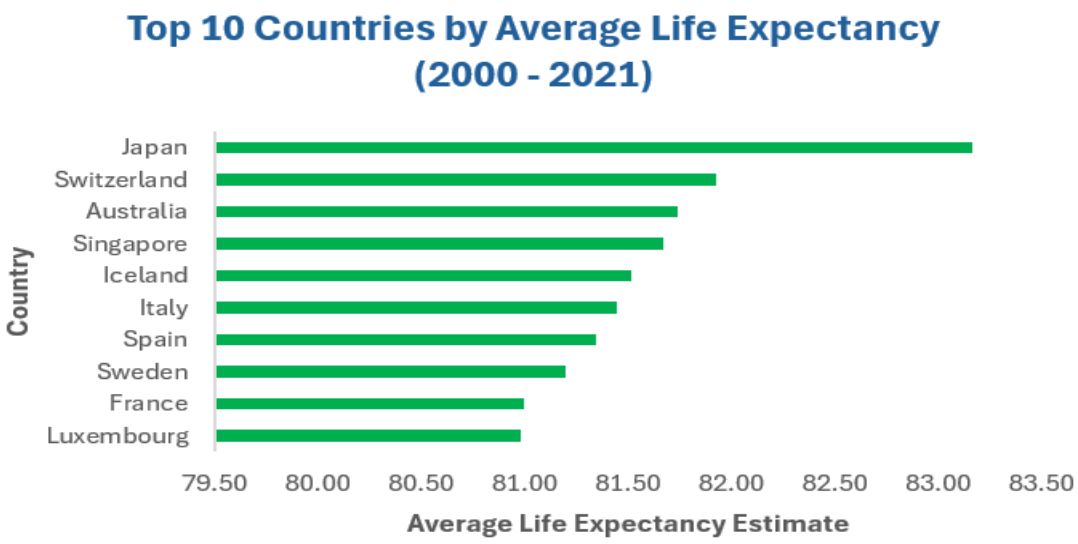
Where the Gaps Are Most Visible

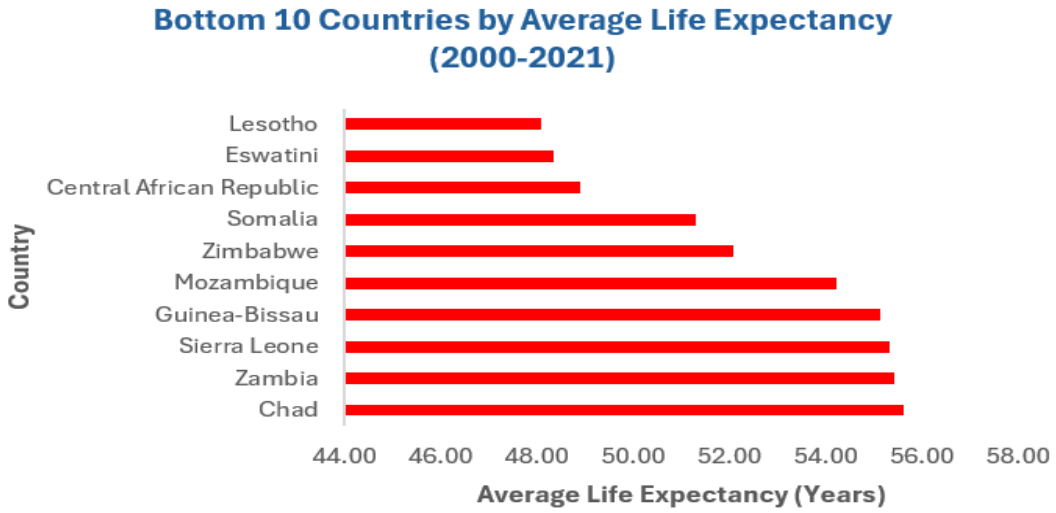
What stood out after visualizing the data

There is a massive gap of about 35 years between the top and bottom countries.

The Leaders: Japan leads the world with an average life expectancy of over 83 years. Other high performers include Switzerland, Australia, and Singapore.

The Laggards: Several countries, including Lesotho, Eswatini, and the Central African Republic, show averages below 50 years.
These results show that where a person is born still has a huge impact on how long they are expected to live.

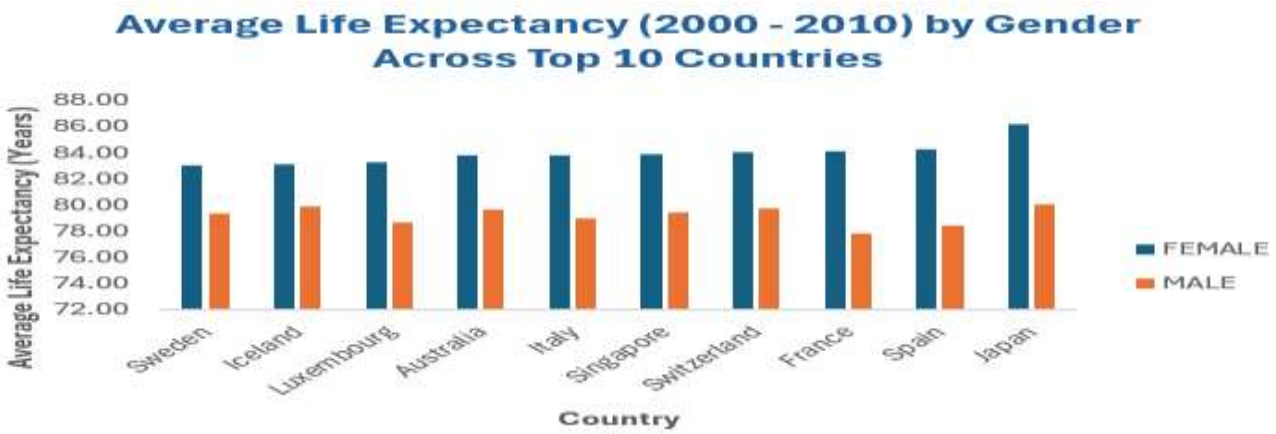


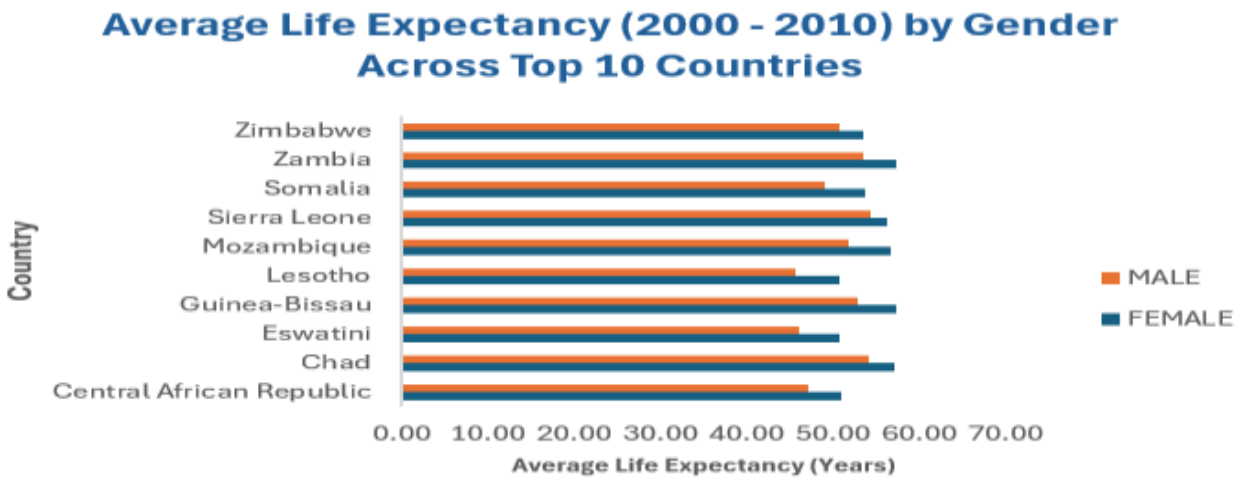


Women Outlive Men in Top and Bottom Countries

The Gender Gap

In every single country analyzed, women are expected to live longer than men. In the top countries, women often live 4 to 5 years longer than men on average.





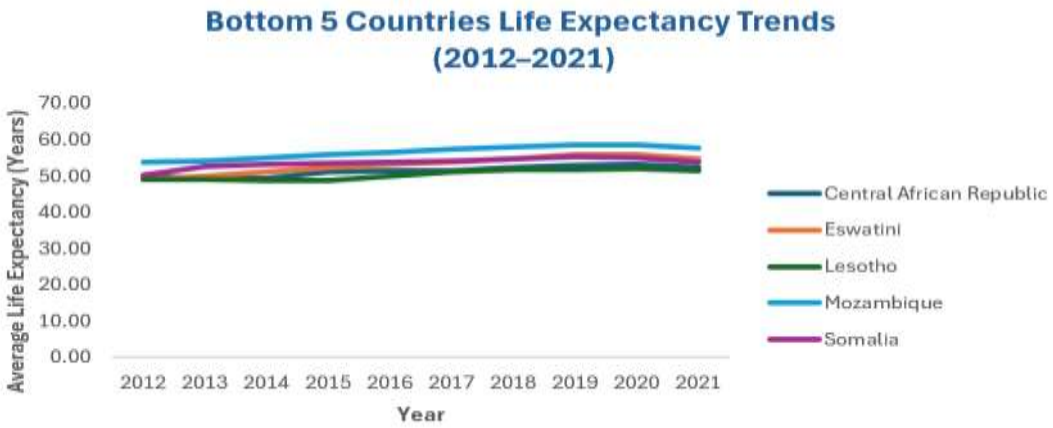
Looking at Recent Trends

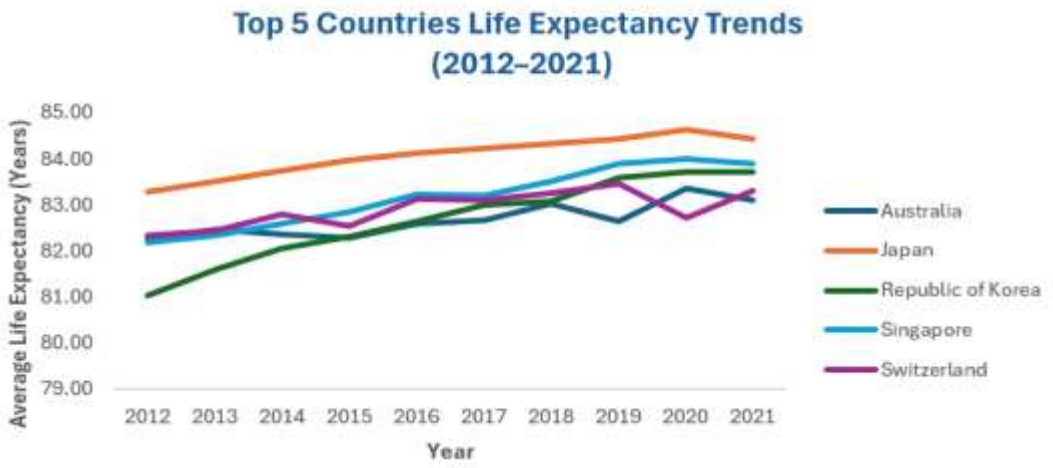
Positive Trends

For the bottom 5 countries, life expectancy was steadily improving (albeit slowly) between 2012 and 2019.

Recent Dips

There was a noticeable stagnation or slight drop in life expectancy for many countries in 2020 and 2021, which may reflect the impact of global health challenges during those years.





What We Learned and What to Consider

Limitations:

This analysis focus is limited to the years 2000 to 2021. It only measures expectancy at birth and does not account for specific causes of death or quality of life.

Assumptions

We assumed the data provided by the UN and WHO is the most accurate representation available for each region.

Conclusion

While global health has improved over the last decade, the divide between the highest and lowest performing nations remains a critical issue that requires attention.